

SUNDAY SCHOOL · AGES 3–5 · 7 WEEKS

The Way Back Home

Little ones: teacher's guide

From God's good garden to the open gates of home. A true Bible story, told with the pictures and clips of **thewaybackhome.net**, and taught the way little ones learn best: by seeing, moving, singing, making and repeating.

Welcome, teacher!

Thank you for teaching our youngest. For seven Sundays, your class will walk the whole Bible story in The Way Back Home: God made a good home, sin locked us out, nothing we do can wash it away, and Jesus, the door, died and rose to bring us home. Each week takes two or three pages of the book and boils them down to **one tiny truth** a three-year-old can say and do with their hands.

This series runs alongside the ages 6–10 and 8–12 series on the same book, week by week, so brothers and sisters learn the same story on the same Sunday and can tell it to each other at home.

The series at a glance

	Week	Say it!	Bible words (CSB)	Kids' pages
1	**God made it good!** The garden, The one rule (pages 1–2)	"God made it all good!"	"…and it was very good indeed." Genesis 1:31	Colour God's good garden · Count what God made · Stick-a-garden (cut and glue)
2	**Listen to God!** The serpent, The fruit, Out of the garden (pages 3–5)	"Listen to God!"	"Every word of God is pure…" Proverbs 30:5	Colour the tree and the snake · Find the 4 sneaky snakes · Story cards 1-2-3 (cut and glue)
3	**Me too** The long road, God's law (pages 6–7)	"We all do wrong. Me too."	"…all have sinned…" Romans 3:23	Draw your face in the mirror · The long road maze · Story cards 1-2-3 (cut and glue)
4	**It won't wash off** Locked out, Can we scrub it off? (pages 8–9)	"I can't wash it off!"	"…it is God's gift." Ephesians 2:8	Trace your hand. Bubbles! · Can soap wash it? Circle or cross · Story cards 1-2-3 (cut and glue)
5	**Jesus is the door** The door, The cross (pages 10–11)	"Jesus is the door!"	"…God loved the world…" John 3:16	Colour the door. Follow the footsteps · Maze: find the way to the door · Door that opens (cut, fold, glue)
6	**Jesus is alive!** The choice, The empty tomb (pages 12–13)	"Jesus is alive!"	"He is not here, but he has risen!" Luke 24:6	Colour the empty tomb · Which tomb is empty? · Roll-away stone (cut and fasten)
7	**Welcome home!** Heaven's gates, The new earth, Follow Jesus (pages 14–16)	"Jesus welcomes me home!"	"We love because he first loved us." 1 John 4:19	Colour heaven's gates. Draw yourself · Maze: run home to Jesus · Gates that open (cut and fold)

What's in this guide

- How little ones learn, and how this series uses it
- A Sunday morning, step by step (60 or 45 minutes)
- Your classroom toolbox: attention cue, redirects, scissors by age
- Sharing Jesus with 3–5s, and how to handle the harder pages
- Supplies and prep for all 7 weeks
- Two pages per week, with a timed plan and words to say
- Answer keys and sources

What's in the kids' pack

Short on paper or ink? Print only **page 1** each week (black and white is fine): it has the colouring, the words to trace and the box for parents. Everything else is optional.

- **Letter to families** (send home in week 1)
- **My Road Home** sticker chart (one per child, keep it in class)
- Each week, **3 pages**: 1 colour and trace, 2 puzzle or maze (with the "For grown-ups" box), 3 cut and glue or a craft
- **Certificate** for week 7

The pictures and story cards are real frames from the book's clips, so children recognise exactly what they saw on screen.

How little ones learn, and how this series uses it

This plan follows patterns found across evangelical preschool curricula and children's ministry guidance (Lifeway, Awana, Child Evangelism Fellowship and others). Numbers in brackets point to the sources at the back of this guide.

What we know about 3–5s	What this series does about it
Attention lasts about one minute per year of age.	No part of the morning runs longer than about 5–8 minutes. We switch between sitting, moving and making all morning. [6]
Plan to win attention back about three times in a 15-minute stretch.	Every plan has a built-in move break, and the toolbox lists quick redirects (motions, copy-me, call and response, touch the picture). [1]
They learn through their senses and by doing.	A feely box, a sock snake, a mirror, a plate that won't scrub clean, a door to knock on, an empty tomb box. Every hook is something to touch. [2][5]
Repetition is how preschoolers learn.	One "Say it!" sentence per week, said whisper-normal-SHOUT, sung, traced and reviewed every week after. The same book, the same routine, the same chart. [2]
Guided play is the best setting for Bible teaching.	Games carry the point: "God says, snake says", "Sleepy… ALIVE!", walking through the door. Play is never just filler. [2]
Keep stories short and simple, avoid symbolism, show the Bible.	Open your Bible to the passage before every story. Play only that week's 2–3 book pages. Explain pictures in plain words: "That's the door. Jesus said He is the door." [5]
Break Bible verses into tiny phrases, add movement, keep it positive.	Each Bible word is a short CSB phrase with motions. Never make memorising a test. [4]
Children imitate adults; your relationship is a "living commentary" on Scripture.	Teachers say "Me too" about their own wrong things, greet every child by name, and pray simply and honestly. [2]
Avoid crafts where the adult does the work.	Kids' pages are built for small hands: big shapes, straight cutting lines for threes, curves for fives, and one helper step at most (the paper fastener). [5][7]

The one-truth rule

A three-year-old will take home one sentence, not five. Every week has exactly one: the **Say it!** line. Hook, story, game, verse, craft and snack all point at that same sentence. If the morning goes sideways and you only manage one thing, make it the Say it! with the moves, three times.

Threes and fives are different

A three-year-old is just learning to snip forward on a line; a five-year-old can cut shapes and retell a story in order. Each week gives you a line for each. Mixed classes work best with one table for "helpers needed" and one for "I can do it myself".

A Sunday morning, step by step

Same order every week. Routine helps little ones feel safe and frees their attention for the story. The times are a guide, not a stopwatch: move on before they get wiggly, not after.

0:00	**Arrival table**	Kids' page 1 (colour and trace) and crayons are out on the table. Greet every child by name, at their eye level. Late arrivals simply join in.
0:08	**Circle and review**	Use the attention cue. Review last weeks' Say it! lines with the moves, then teach today's: whisper it, say it, SHOUT it.
0:12	**Hook**	Something to touch, see or do that opens the one truth (5 minutes).
0:17	**Story time**	Open your Bible to the passage. Play this week's book pages on a screen. Pause on each picture with one question.
0:25	**Wiggle and play**	A movement game that carries the truth.
0:32	**Bible words**	The short CSB phrase, with motions, said several ways (loud, quiet, fast, slow).
0:35	**Table time**	Kids' pages 2 and 3: puzzle or maze, then cut and glue or craft. Talk while they work.
0:47	**Snack and talk**	A snack that ties to the story, with the talk questions.
0:53	**Say it, sticker, pray**	The Say it! with the moves one last time (or a song you know), a sticker on the Road Home chart, a short prayer, pages into bags.
0:60	**Goodbye**	Say it! one last time with each parent at the door.

Only 45 minutes?

- Arrival table: 5 minutes
- Drop the separate Bible words slot; say the verse during the wiggle game
- Snack only if your church normally has one
- Send page 1 home unfinished if needed; pages 2 and 3 are the ones to do in class

Only 30 minutes (e.g. during the sermon)?

- Hook 5 · Story 7 · Wiggle 6 · Page 3 craft 8 · Say it and pray 4
- Send pages 1 and 2 home

Set up the room

- **Story rug** facing the screen, away from the door and the craft table
- **Craft table** with pages, crayons, glue sticks and scissors in a tub per table
- **Open floor** for games (push chairs back)
- **Road Home charts** on the wall at child height
- Screen: a TV, laptop or tablet. Download the book for offline use from the site's menu in case the Wi-Fi fails

Helpers

- Aim for one adult per 4–5 threes, or 6–8 fives
- Two screened adults in the room at all times, following your church's child-safety policy
- Give helpers this page and the week's plan the Sunday before
- One helper owns the craft table so the lead teacher can keep the story moving

Your classroom toolbox

The attention cue: "Way back…" "HOME!"

Teach it in week 1 and use it every time you need the room. You say **"Way back…"** in a sing-song voice; children answer **"HOME!"** and put their hands on their heads (a roof). Use the same cue every time: little ones do well with routine. [6]

Quick redirects (have three ready)

- **Freeze frame!** The book's clips freeze on their last picture. Call "Freeze frame!" and everyone freezes like the picture.
- **Copy me:** touch nose, ears, toes, then sit.
- **Call and response:** "Kids, kids!" "Yes, yes!" [1]
- **Touch the picture:** invite one child at a time to come and touch Jesus on the screen, then sit down. [1]
- **The moves:** do this week's Say it! moves together.
- **Whisper:** drop your voice. They lean in.

When a child won't join in

- Give them a job: hold the snake, open the door, roll the stone. [6]
- Seat them next to you; say their name warmly.
- Let shy ones watch. Watching is learning at this age.
- Unexpected comments are teaching moments: acknowledge, then bring it back. [1]

Scissors by age (averages; children vary) [7]

Age	Typical skill	On page 3
3	Snips forward; cuts a straight 6-inch line within about ½ inch	Pre-cut pages 3, or let them tear. They glue and tell.
3½–4	Straight lines within ¼ inch; starts curves and big circles	Cut the story cards themselves (straight lines). Help with the stone and doors.
4½–5	Squares and simple shapes within ¼ inch	Cut everything except the paper fastener. Retell the cards in order.

Printing

- US Letter; prints fine on A4 at "fit to page".
- Print story-card pages (weeks 2–4) and craft pages (5–7) **in colour** if you can. Everything else works in black and white.
- Card stock helps for page 3 in weeks 5–7.
- Print one Road Home chart per child for the wall, plus 2 spares for visitors.

Safety

- Check allergies before every snack (nuts, gluten, dairy). Swap freely.
- Child-safe scissors only; collect them before snack.
- Paper fasteners (week 6) are small: an adult fastens them.
- Cut grapes lengthways for under-fives.
- Follow your church's policy on photos and check-out.

Sharing Jesus with little ones

Preschoolers can understand that God loves them, that they do wrong things, and that Jesus died and rose for them, especially when they hear it again and again at church and at home. Think of yourself as a seed planter: share the gospel clearly and often, and trust God with the timing. [3]

The good news in little words

1. **God made me and loves me.** He wants me home with Him. (weeks 1, 7)
2. **I do wrong things. Everybody does.** Wrong things keep us away from God, and I can't wash them off. (weeks 2–4)
3. **Jesus never did wrong. He died for me and came alive again.** (weeks 5–6)
4. **I can say sorry to God and trust Jesus.** He makes my heart clean and will welcome me home. (weeks 6–7)

Do

- Speak of sin and of Jesus simply and truly, in their words (grumpy, fibs, not sharing).
- Invite, quietly: "If you want to talk to Jesus about this, you can talk to me after." [3]
- Talk one-to-one with a child who asks questions, and tell the parents the same day. [3]
- Connect punishment to consequences they know: "When we do wrong at home, there's a consequence. God is fair too." [3]
- End every hard moment with hope: "But God has a plan!"

Don't

- Pressure. Little ones are eager to please adults. [3]
- Ask for raised hands or for children to come forward; they copy each other. [3]
- Ask a child directly "Do you want to trust Jesus?" unless they have shown real readiness. [3]
- Make it scary, or so entertaining that the point is lost. [5]
- Count or announce "decisions".

The harder pages, and how to handle them

Week 2 · The fruit	A lightning flash and thunder. Lower the volume a little; sit near anyone who startles. "Uh-oh. That was a sad day."
Week 2 · Out of the garden	Animals died to make clothes. Say it quietly and briefly. It matters in week 5: "Someone has to take our place."
Week 3 · God's law	"That makes you a liar and a thief." Land on "We all do wrong. Me too." Use yourself as the example, never a child.
Week 4 · Locked out	The book names hell. Say it once, calmly, then straight to hope (see week 4). Your church may prefer to read this page aloud yourself.
Weeks 5–6 · Cross, choice	One child in the book turns away. "He doesn't want Jesus yet. Jesus still loves him. Jesus lets us choose."

Supplies and prep for all 7 weeks

Every week

- A screen (TV, laptop or tablet) with **thewaybackhome.net**, downloaded for offline use
- Your Bible, bookmarked at the week's passage
- Kids' pages 1–3 for each child, plus spares
- Crayons, glue sticks, child-safe scissors
- Round stickers for the Road Home chart
- A bag or folder per child for take-home pages
- Snack, wipes, allergy list

Once, before week 1

- Print the letter to families and the Road Home charts
- Make the sock-snake puppet (week 2)
- Test the permanent-marker plate and rubbing alcohol at home (weeks 4 and 6)
- Make the shoebox tomb with a paper-plate stone (week 6)
- Buy paper fasteners (week 6) and bubbles (week 7)
- Teach helpers the attention cue and the Say it! moves

Special items, by week

Item	Week
A box or pillowcase	1
Leaf, flower, stone, feather	1
Glue sticks	1, 2, 3, 4, 5
Child-safe scissors	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7
A sock with two button eyes (snake puppet)	2
A hand mirror	3
Small round dot stickers (1 per person)	3
White plastic plate	4
Permanent marker	4
Bowl of water and a sponge	4
Tub of soapy water, toy dishes, towels	4
A door, or a blanket to hold up	5
Shoebox with a paper-plate "stone"	6
Last week's marker plate + rubbing alcohol and a cloth	6
Paper fasteners (brads), 1 per child	6
Bubbles or streamers	7
Last Road Home stickers	7
Certificates	7

Running threads (don't lose these!)

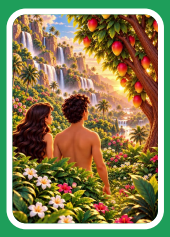
- **Dot stickers** go on in week 3 ("a spot for everyone") and come off in week 5 when children walk through the door.
- **The spotty plate** won't scrub clean in week 4, and is wiped clean in week 6.
- **The Road Home chart** gets one sticker every week and goes home with the certificate in week 7.

WEEK 1 OF 7

God made it good!

Book: The garden · The one rule (pages 1–2) · Bible: Genesis 1–2





Teacher's heart

Before sin, before the long road, there was home. God made a good world and put Adam and Eve in it to live with Him. He gave them everything to enjoy, and one simple rule: not that tree. The rule was not a trap; it was a loving Father giving His children a way to trust Him. This week plants the whole series in one picture: home is where God is, and God made it good.

Today's one truth

Every child goes home knowing: God made everything, God made me, and it was good.

Say it!

"God made it all good!"

Throw your arms wide on "all", then a big thumbs up on "good!"
Say it three ways: whisper, normal, SHOUT.

Bible words

"...and it was very good indeed."

Genesis 1:31 (CSB). Motions: "Very good" = two thumbs up. "Indeed!" = jump.

Story time: pause and ask

Open your Bible to Genesis 1–2 first: "This true story comes from God's Book." Then play the pages at thewaybackhome.net.

- **The garden:** Point to a flower. Who made it? Who is with Adam and Eve? (God!)
- **The one rule:** What is Adam pointing at? Every tree was for them except one.

You need

- Screen with the book, your Bible
- A box or pillowcase
- Leaf, flower, stone, feather
- Glue sticks
- Child-safe scissors
- Kids' pages 1–3, crayons, Road Home stickers

Talk (at snack or table time)

- Who made the trees? The birds? The fish? You?
- God made Adam and Eve a garden home. Was it a happy place?
- What was the one rule?

Week 1 · The plan

0:00	**Arrival table**	Kids' page 1: "Colour God's good garden. Count the fruit!" Greet each child by name.
0:08	**Circle**	Attention cue. Teach the attention cue ("Way back…" "HOME!"). Then teach today's Say it! with the moves.
0:12	**Hook: Feely box**	Put a leaf, a flower, a smooth stone and a feather in a box. One by one, children reach in without looking. "What is it? Who made it?" Everyone shouts: "God did!"
0:17	**Story time**	Bible open at Genesis 1–2. Play The garden, The one rule (pages 1–2). Use the pause questions on page 1.
0:25	**Play: God made…**	"God made frogs!" Everyone hops. Birds flap. Fish swim. Elephants stomp. Then whisper, "God made… YOU!" and everyone hugs themselves.
0:32	**Bible words**	"…and it was very good indeed." (Genesis 1:31). Break it into tiny pieces; children echo each one, then add the motions.
0:35	**Table time**	Kids' pages 2 and 3: Count what God made and Stick-a-garden (cut and glue). Page 2 first (counting), then page 3: cut out the six squares and glue them into the garden. Threes tear or have the squares pre-cut; fives cut on their own.
0:47	**Snack: "God made fruit!"**	Orange segments, banana coins or grapes (cut lengthways for little ones). Before eating: "God gave Adam and Eve every tree but one. What fruit did God make for us today?" Then the talk questions (page 1).
0:53	**Say it, sticker, pray**	The Say it! with the moves once more (add a song you know if you like). Sticker on stop 1 of the Road Home chart. Pray: "Thank You, God, for making ___." Let each child fill in the blank: puppies, Mummy, rain, me.
0:60	**Goodbye**	Pages 1–3 into bags. Do the Say it! with each parent at the door. Page 2's grown-ups box asks: "Who made the trees and the flowers? Who made you?"

Threes

Name things as they colour: "God made that bird!" One sentence of truth, said many times, is the lesson.

Fives

Ask them to tell you the one rule in their own words, and to find the six things God made on page 3 before cutting.

Teacher tip

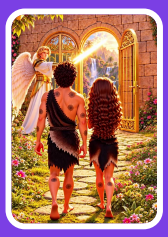
Short and happy. Three- and four-year-olds learn by doing: let them touch, stick, move and shout. Joy is the point this week.

WEEK 2 OF 7

Listen to God!

Book: The serpent · The fruit · Out of the garden (pages 3–5) · Bible: Genesis 3





Teacher's heart

The serpent's first words were a question about God's word: "Did God really say that?" Then a lie: "You won't die!" Eve and Adam believed the lie and ate. Everything changed. They hid, they were ashamed, and they had to leave the garden. Yet God still came to them, clothed them, and made a promise: Someone would come to crush the serpent and open the way back home (Genesis 3:15). For little ones the truth is simple: God always tells the truth, so we listen to Him.

Today's one truth

Every child goes home knowing: God always tells the truth. We listen to God.

Say it!

"Listen to God!"

Cup a hand behind your ear on "Listen", then point up high on "God!"
Say it three ways: whisper, normal, SHOUT.

Bible words

"Every word of God is pure…"

Proverbs 30:5 (CSB). Motions: "Every word" = open hands like a book. "Pure" = hands flat and still, like clean water.

Story time: pause and ask

Open your Bible to Genesis 3 first: "This true story comes from God's Book." Then play the pages at thewaybackhome.net.

- **The serpent:** What is the snake doing? Was he telling the truth?
- **The fruit:** Uh-oh. What did Adam and Eve do? How do they feel?
- **Out of the garden:** God still loved them. He made them clothes and a promise: Someone would come!

You need

- Screen with the book, your Bible
- A sock with two button eyes (snake puppet)
- Glue sticks
- Child-safe scissors
- Kids' pages 1–3, crayons, Road Home stickers

Talk (at snack or table time)

- What did the sneaky snake say to Eve?
- Did Adam and Eve listen to God? How did they feel after?
- God made a promise. Someone would come. Who do you think it is? (We'll find out!)

Week 2 · The plan

0:00	**Arrival table**	Kids' page 1: "Colour the tree. Can you see the sneaky snake?" Greet each child by name.
0:08	**Circle**	Attention cue. Review with the moves: "God made it all good!". Then teach today's Say it! with the moves.
0:12	**Hook: Sneaky sock snake**	A sock snake on your hand whispers silly wrong things: "Don't share your toys!" "Eat ALL the cookies!" "Grown-ups don't mean it!" Children shout back: "No! Listen to God!"
0:17	**Story time**	Bible open at Genesis 3. Play The serpent, The fruit, Out of the garden (pages 3–5). Use the pause questions on page 1.
0:25	**Play: God says, snake says**	Like Simon Says. "God says jump!" Everyone jumps. When the sock snake says "Jump!", nobody moves. Anyone who moves just shouts "Listen to God!" and stays in.
0:32	**Bible words**	"Every word of God is pure…" (Proverbs 30:5). Break it into tiny pieces; children echo each one, then add the motions.
0:35	**Table time**	Kids' pages 2 and 3: Find the 4 sneaky snakes and Story cards 1-2-3 (cut and glue). Page 2: hunt for the four hidden snakes and circle them. Page 3: cut out the three story pictures and glue them in order. Then each child "reads" their strip to a leader.
0:47	**Snack: Snakes and truth**	Pretzel sticks "snakes" or a fruit-and-cheese "snake" in a line. Ask: "Did the snake tell the truth? Who always tells the truth?" Then the talk questions (page 1).
0:53	**Say it, sticker, pray**	The Say it! with the moves once more (add a song you know if you like). Sticker on stop 2 of the Road Home chart. Pray: "Dear God, You always tell the truth. Help me listen to You. Amen."
0:60	**Goodbye**	Pages 1–3 into bags. Do the Say it! with each parent at the door. Page 2's grown-ups box asks: "What did the snake say? Who always tells the truth?"

Threes

Keep the snake silly, not scary. A three-year-old only needs: "The snake said a fib. God tells the truth."

Fives

Fives can retell the three cards: "The snake lied, they ate the fruit, they had to leave." Ask, "What did God promise?"

Teacher tip

The fruit page has a lightning flash and a thunder sound. Turn the volume down a little, sit close to any child who startles, and say calmly: "Uh-oh. That was a sad day."

Handle with care

The book says animals died to make Adam and Eve's clothes. Say it simply and quietly: "God made them clothes. It was a sad day." It matters later (week 5), so don't skip it, and don't dwell on it.

WEEK 3 OF 7

Me too

Book: The long road · God's law (pages 6–7) · Bible: Romans 3:23 · Exodus 20





Teacher's heart

Adam and Eve's children had children, all the way down to us, and every one of us carries sin. God gave His good rules, the Ten Commandments, and like a mirror they show us what we could not see: we have all broken God's law. Preschoolers understand "wrong things" long before they understand "sin". Your honest, cheerful "Me too" is the most powerful teaching tool you have this week. It tells them this is true of everyone, and it is safe to say so.

Today's one truth

Every child goes home knowing: everybody does wrong things. Me too. God sees my heart.

Say it!

"We all do wrong. Me too."

Point all around the circle on "We all", then point to yourself on "Me too."
Say it three ways: whisper, normal, SHOUT.

Bible words

"...all have sinned..."

Romans 3:23 (CSB). Motions: "All" = sweep an arm around the room. "Sinned" = sad face, hands over heart.

Story time: pause and ask

Open your Bible to Romans 3:23 · Exodus 20 first: "This true story comes from God's Book." Then play the pages at thewaybackhome.net.

- **The long road:** Look at all the people! Do you see spots? Everybody has them.
- **God's law:** "Have you ever told a lie?" Pause. Put your own hand up: "Me too."

You need

- Screen with the book, your Bible
- A hand mirror
- Small round dot stickers (1 per person)
- Glue sticks
- Child-safe scissors
- Kids' pages 1–3, crayons, Road Home stickers

Talk (at snack or table time)

- Have you ever been grumpy? Not shared? Said something unkind? Told a fib?
- Does everybody do wrong things? Even grown-ups? Even teachers? (Yes. Me too.)
- God sees our hearts, and He still loves us.

Week 3 · The plan

0:00	**Arrival table**	Kids' page 1: "Draw your face in the mirror. God sees your heart!" Greet each child by name.
0:08	**Circle**	Attention cue. Review with the moves: "God made it all good!" · "Listen to God!". Then teach today's Say it! with the moves.
0:12	**Hook: Look in the mirror**	Pass a hand mirror around. Each child looks and makes a funny face. Then say softly: "A mirror shows your face. God's rules are like a mirror. They show what's inside: our hearts."
0:17	**Story time**	Bible open at Romans 3:23 · Exodus 20. Play The long road, God's law (pages 6–7). Use the pause questions on page 1.
0:25	**Play: A spot for everyone**	Give every child one round dot sticker on the back of the hand: a "wrong spot". Give one to every leader too. Look around: "Does anyone not have a spot?" Keep the spots on; you'll need them in week 5.
0:32	**Bible words**	"…all have sinned…" (Romans 3:23). Break it into tiny pieces; children echo each one, then add the motions.
0:35	**Table time**	Kids' pages 2 and 3: The long road maze and Story cards 1-2-3 (cut and glue). Page 2: walk a finger along the road first, then a crayon. Page 3: cut and glue the three road pictures in order.
0:47	**Snack: One spot each**	Round crackers with one raisin (or chocolate chip) "spot" on each. Everybody gets a spot. Me too! Then the talk questions (page 1).
0:53	**Say it, sticker, pray**	The Say it! with the moves once more (add a song you know if you like). Sticker on stop 3 of the Road Home chart. Pray: "Dear God, I do wrong things too. Thank You that You love me. Amen."
0:60	**Goodbye**	Pages 1–3 into bags. Do the Say it! with each parent at the door. Page 2's grown-ups box asks: "Does everybody do wrong things? Do you? Do I?"

Threes

Use their words: grumpy, not sharing, hitting, fibs. Never single out a child's behaviour as the example; use your own.

Teacher tip

Say "Me too" about yourself, cheerfully and truthfully: "Yesterday I was grumpy with my family." Little ones learn honesty by watching you.

Fives

Ask, "What are God's good rules like?" (a mirror). Fives can name two: don't lie, don't take what isn't yours.

Handle with care

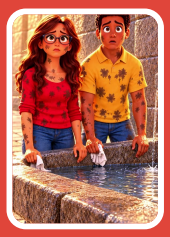
The book asks, "Have you ever told a lie?" and says "that makes you a liar and a thief." For this age, gently land on the point, not the label: "We all do wrong things. Me too." No child should leave feeling singled out.

WEEK 4 OF 7

It won't wash off

Book: Locked out · Can we scrub it off? (pages 8–9) · Bible: Ephesians 2:8–9





Teacher's heart

Sin is not a smudge we can scrub off. Being extra good, saying sorry, even going to church cannot erase what we have done. The book shows the children scrubbing and scrubbing, and the marks stay. Sin locks us out of God's home, just as Adam and Eve were locked out of the garden. This is the bad news that makes the good news good. Teach it truthfully and end every part of the morning with hope: "But God has a plan!"

Today's one truth

Every child goes home knowing: I can't wash the wrong away by myself. But God has a plan!

Say it!

"I can't wash it off!"

Scrub your hands hard together, then stop and shake your head on "can't".
Say it three ways: whisper, normal, SHOUT.

Bible words

"...it is God's gift."

Ephesians 2:8 (CSB). Motions: "God's gift" = hold out two cupped hands, like receiving a present.

Story time: pause and ask

Open your Bible to Ephesians 2:8–9 first: "This true story comes from God's Book." Then play the pages at thewaybackhome.net.

- **Locked out:** The gates are shut. Can the children get in?
- **Can we scrub it off?:** They scrub and scrub. Did it work? (No!) Who can help? "But God has a plan!"

You need

- Screen with the book, your Bible
- White plastic plate
- Permanent marker
- Bowl of water and a sponge
- Tub of soapy water, toy dishes, towels
- Glue sticks
- Child-safe scissors
- Kids' pages 1–3, crayons, Road Home stickers

Talk (at snack or table time)

- The children in the book tried to wash their spots off. Did it work?
- Can being extra good wash away wrong things? Can saying sorry? (They are good, but they can't wash sin away.)
- Who can help us? "Next week we meet Him!"

Week 4 · The plan

0:00	**Arrival table**	Kids' page 1: "Trace your hand. Colour the soap bubbles!" Greet each child by name.
0:08	**Circle**	Attention cue. Review with the moves: "God made it all good!" · "Listen to God!" · "We all do wrong. Me too.". Then teach today's Say it! with the moves.
0:12	**Hook: The plate that stays dirty**	Draw a spot on a white plastic plate with a permanent marker before class. Let each child try to scrub it with a wet sponge. It won't come off! Put the plate away safely for week 6.
0:17	**Story time**	Bible open at Ephesians 2:8–9. Play Locked out, Can we scrub it off? (pages 8–9). Use the pause questions on page 1.
0:25	**Play: Wash-the-dishes game**	A tub of soapy water and toy dishes. Children wash and dry (messy fun!). Then hold up the marked plate: "Some spots we can wash. But the wrong things in our hearts? Only God can take those away."
0:32	**Bible words**	"…it is God's gift." (Ephesians 2:8). Break it into tiny pieces; children echo each one, then add the motions.
0:35	**Table time**	Kids' pages 2 and 3: Can soap wash it? Circle or cross and Story cards 1-2-3 (cut and glue). Page 2: circle what soap can wash; put a big X on the heart. Page 3: cut and glue the three pictures in order.
0:47	**Snack: Wash first!**	Everyone washes hands before snack (talk about it as you wash). Vanilla wafers with one chocolate-chip "spot". "Can we scrub it off?" Then the talk questions (page 1).
0:53	**Say it, sticker, pray**	The Say it! with the moves once more (add a song you know if you like). Sticker on stop 4 of the Road Home chart. Pray: "Dear God, I can't wash away the wrong things I do. Thank You that You have a plan. Amen."
0:60	**Goodbye**	Pages 1–3 into bags. Do the Say it! with each parent at the door. Page 2's grown-ups box asks: "Can we wash the wrong things in our hearts away by ourselves? Who has a plan?"

Threes

Threes will love the water. That's fine. The one sentence to repeat while they splash: "Soap can't wash our hearts."

Teacher tip

Keep the permanent-marker plate somewhere safe. In week 6 it comes back, and you wipe it clean with rubbing alcohol (test it at home first).

Fives

Fives can say why: "Being good tomorrow can't erase what we did today." Ask, "What did God give Adam and Eve to cover them?" (clothes), to point ahead to week 5.

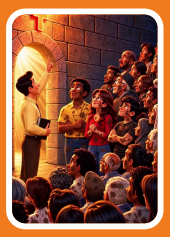
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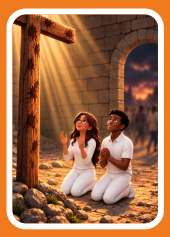
The "Locked out" page says that if we die with our sin we will be punished in a place called hell, far away from God. It is true and the book says it plainly. For 3–5s, say it once, calmly and briefly, then move straight to hope: "That is very sad news. But God has a plan to bring us home!" Don't add pictures or detail. If a child is worried, sit with them: "Jesus came to make a way for us. We'll hear about Him next week." Your church may prefer that the teacher reads this page aloud rather than playing it.

WEEK 5 OF 7

Jesus is the door

Book: The door · The cross (pages 10–11) · Bible: John 10:9 · John 3:16





Teacher's heart

Here is the good news! The Someone God promised in the garden is Jesus, God's own Son. Jesus said, "I am the door. Whoever comes in through Me will be saved" (John 10:9). Jesus never sinned, not even once, but He died on the cross in our place, like the animals that died for Adam and Eve. All our sin was put on Him. Little ones understand love before they understand ideas, so lead with love: "Jesus died for me because He loves me."

Today's one truth

Every child goes home knowing: Jesus is the door to God. Jesus loves me so much He died for me.

Say it!

"Jesus is the door!"

Make a door with your arms in front of you, then swing them wide open on "door!"
Say it three ways: whisper, normal, SHOUT.

Bible words

"...God loved the world..."

John 3:16 (CSB). Motions: "God" = point up. "Loved" = hug yourself. "The world" = draw a big circle with both arms.

Story time: pause and ask

Open your Bible to John 10:9 · John 3:16 first: "This true story comes from God's Book." Then play the pages at thewaybackhome.net.

- **The door:** Who is the door to God's home? (Jesus!) Look how happy the people are to tell others.
- **The cross:** Jesus never did anything wrong. He died for us because He loves us. How much? Arms out: THIS much!

You need

- Screen with the book, your Bible
- A door, or a blanket to hold up
- Glue sticks
- Child-safe scissors
- Kids' pages 1–3, crayons, Road Home stickers

Talk (at snack or table time)

- Who is the door to God's home?
- Did Jesus ever do wrong things? (Never!)
- Why did Jesus die on the cross? (Because He loves us. He took our wrong things.)

Week 5 · The plan

0:00	**Arrival table**	Kids' page 1: "Colour the door. Follow the footsteps to the door!" Greet each child by name.
0:08	**Circle**	Attention cue. Review with the moves: "God made it all good!" · "Listen to God!" · "We all do wrong. Me too." · "I can't wash it off!". Then teach today's Say it! with the moves.
0:12	**Hook: Knock, knock!**	Stand behind a closed door (or a blanket two leaders hold up). Children knock: "Knock, knock!" Open it wide with a huge smile and welcome each child through by name. "Jesus said, 'I am the door.' He opens the way to God!"
0:17	**Story time**	Bible open at John 10:9 · John 3:16. Play The door, The cross (pages 10–11). Use the pause questions on page 1.
0:25	**Play: Through the door**	Two leaders hold hands high to make a doorway. Children walk or crawl through to a "home" blanket for a high five, shouting "Jesus is the door!" each time. Last time through: peel off last week's dot stickers. "Jesus takes our wrong things away!"
0:32	**Bible words**	"…God loved the world…" (John 3:16). Break it into tiny pieces; children echo each one, then add the motions.
0:35	**Table time**	Kids' pages 2 and 3: Maze: find the way to the door and Door that opens (cut, fold, glue). Page 2: the maze. Page 3: leaders pre-cut the door for threes; fives cut the three solid lines themselves, fold the door open, and glue the picture behind it.
0:47	**Snack: Door snacks**	Rectangle crackers or graham crackers as "doors". Before eating, everyone knocks on their cracker: "Jesus is the door!" Then the talk questions (page 1).
0:53	**Say it, sticker, pray**	The Say it! with the moves once more (add a song you know if you like). Sticker on stop 5 of the Road Home chart. Pray: "Thank You, Jesus, for loving me so much. Thank You for being the door. Amen."
0:60	**Goodbye**	Pages 1–3 into bags. Do the Say it! with each parent at the door. Page 2's grown-ups box asks: "Who is the door? How much does Jesus love you?"

Threes

Keep the cross simple and full of love. Three-year-olds need only: "Jesus died for me because He loves me. Then… (wait for next week!)"

Teacher tip

Never end on the cross without a hint of Sunday: "But that's not the end of the story! Come back next week!"

Fives

Fives can connect it: "The animals died for Adam and Eve. Jesus died for us." Ask, "Who did God promise would come?"

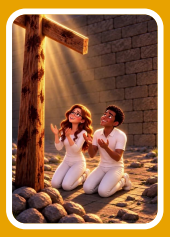
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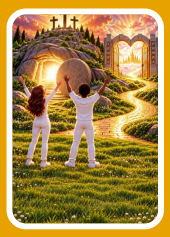
On the cross page one of the book's three children (Chase) turns away. If a child asks, answer gently: "He doesn't want Jesus yet. Jesus still loves him." The kids' pages this week use the picture of the children kneeling in white instead.

WEEK 6 OF 7

Jesus is alive!

Book: The choice · The empty tomb (pages 12–13) · Bible: Luke 24 · Isaiah 1:18





Teacher's heart

Three days after Jesus died, His friends found the tomb empty. Jesus was alive! He beat sin and death. Everyone who trusts Him is made "as clean and white as snow" (Isaiah 1:18). The book also shows a choice: some people say "No thanks", and others say sorry to God and trust Jesus. For little ones, keep it warm and simple: Jesus is alive, Jesus makes us clean, and Jesus wants us. This is a party week.

Today's one truth

Every child goes home knowing: Jesus is ALIVE! Jesus can make my heart clean.

Say it!

"Jesus is alive!"

Crouch down low, then jump up high with your arms in the air on "alive!"
Say it three ways: whisper, normal, SHOUT.

Bible words

"He is not here, but he has risen!"

Luke 24:6 (CSB). Motions: "Not here" = shake head, hands out. "Risen!" = jump up, arms high.

Story time: pause and ask

Open your Bible to Luke 24 · Isaiah 1:18 first: "This true story comes from God's Book." Then play the pages at thewaybackhome.net.

- **The choice:** Some people say "No thanks." Others say "Sorry" to God and trust Jesus. Look: their clothes are white!
- **The empty tomb:** Is Jesus in the tomb? (No!) Where is He? He is alive!

You need

- Screen with the book, your Bible
- Shoebox with a paper-plate "stone"
- Last week's marker plate + rubbing alcohol and a cloth
- Paper fasteners (brads), 1 per child
- Child-safe scissors
- Kids' pages 1–3, crayons, Road Home stickers

Talk (at snack or table time)

- Was Jesus still in the tomb? Where is He now?
- What happened to the spotty plate? (It's clean!) Jesus can make our hearts clean.
- Some people say "No thanks" to Jesus. Jesus still loves them. What would you say?

Week 6 · The plan

0:00	**Arrival table**	Kids' page 1: "Colour the empty tomb. Trace the sun's rays!" Greet each child by name.
0:08	**Circle**	Attention cue. Review with the moves: "God made it all good!" · "Listen to God!" · "We all do wrong. Me too." · "I can't wash it off!" · "Jesus is the door!". Then teach today's Say it! with the moves.
0:12	**Hook: The empty box**	A shoebox "tomb" with a paper-plate "stone" on the front. "Jesus' friends came to His tomb, very sad…" Roll the stone away slowly. Look inside. Empty! "He is not here! He is ALIVE!"
0:17	**Story time**	Bible open at Luke 24 · Isaiah 1:18. Play The choice, The empty tomb (pages 12–13). Use the pause questions on page 1.
0:25	**Play: Sleepy, sleepy… ALIVE!**	Everyone lies down very still. Whisper: "Shhh… sleepy…" Then shout "Jesus is ALIVE!" and everyone jumps up cheering. Then bring out the spotty plate from week 4 and wipe it clean in front of them: "Jesus makes us clean!"
0:32	**Bible words**	"He is not here, but he has risen!" (Luke 24:6). Break it into tiny pieces; children echo each one, then add the motions.
0:35	**Table time**	Kids' pages 2 and 3: Which tomb is empty? and Roll-away stone (cut and fasten). Page 2: circle the empty tomb, then colour the sun. Page 3: cut out the stone, and a leader fastens it with a paper fastener so it rolls away to show "He is alive!"
0:47	**Snack: Party!**	Something celebratory: mini muffins or fruit kebabs. If you have an oven, "empty tomb" resurrection rolls are a classic (marshmallow wrapped in dough "disappears"). Then the talk questions (page 1).
0:53	**Say it, sticker, pray**	The Say it! with the moves once more (add a song you know if you like). Sticker on stop 6 of the Road Home chart. Pray: "Jesus, You are alive! Thank You for making hearts clean. Amen."
0:60	**Goodbye**	Pages 1–3 into bags. Do the Say it! with each parent at the door. Page 2's grown-ups box asks: "Where is Jesus now? Is He alive? What can He do for our hearts?"

Threes

Big voices, big jumps, big smiles. The one sentence: "Jesus is alive!"

Fives

Ask the choice question gently and openly; never ask for a show of hands. Fives can say what Jesus does for those who trust Him: makes them clean.

Teacher tip

Test the rubbing alcohol on a marked plate at home first. The clean-plate moment is the high point of the morning, so make it dramatic.

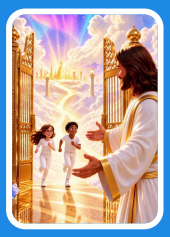
Handle with care

On the choice page, Chase walks away ("No thanks"). That's the point of the page: everyone has a choice. Keep your tone warm: "Jesus still loves him. Jesus lets us choose." Don't ask children to choose publicly.

WEEK 7 OF 7

Welcome home!

Book: Heaven's gates · The new earth · Follow Jesus (pages 14–16) · Bible: John 14:2–3 · Revelation 21





Teacher's heart

The story ends where it began: home with God. One day everyone who trusts Jesus will run through heaven's open gates, and Jesus will be there with His arms wide open, the scars still in His hands. God will make everything new, even better than Eden. Until then, Jesus asks us to tell others the good news. This week gathers the whole story and invites each child, gently and without pressure, to talk to Jesus.

Today's one truth

Every child goes home knowing: Jesus loves me and wants me home with Him. I can talk to Him and tell others.

Say it!

"Jesus welcomes me home!"

Open your arms wide, then give yourself a big hug on "home!"
Say it three ways: whisper, normal, SHOUT.

Bible words

"We love because he first loved us."

1 John 4:19 (CSB). Motions: "We love" = cross arms over heart. "He first" = point up, then hold up one finger.

Story time: pause and ask

Open your Bible to John 14:2–3 · Revelation 21 first: "This true story comes from God's Book." Then play the pages at thewaybackhome.net.

- **Heaven's gates:** Who is waiting with open arms? Look at His hands. Those are the scars of His love.
- **The new earth:** God will make everything new! What would you like to see there?
- **Follow Jesus:** Read the A-B-C slowly. Pause the screen here for the invitation (see below).

You need

- Screen with the book, your Bible
- Bubbles or streamers
- Last Road Home stickers
- Certificates
- Child-safe scissors
- Kids' pages 1–3, crayons, Road Home stickers

Talk (at snack or table time)

- Who is waiting at heaven's gates with open arms?
- What will it be like when God makes everything new?
- Who can you tell about Jesus this week?

Week 7 · The plan

0:00	**Arrival table**	Kids' page 1: "Colour heaven's gates. Draw yourself running home!" Greet each child by name.
0:08	**Circle**	Attention cue. Review with the moves: "God made it all good!" · "Listen to God!" · "We all do wrong. Me too." · "I can't wash it off!" · "Jesus is the door!" · "Jesus is alive!". Then teach today's Say it! with the moves.
0:12	**Hook: Welcome-home tunnel**	Leaders make a high-five tunnel at the door and cheer each child in by name: "Welcome home!" Bubbles and streamers if you can!
0:17	**Story time**	Bible open at John 14:2–3 · Revelation 21. Play Heaven's gates, The new earth, Follow Jesus (pages 14–16). Use the pause questions on page 1.
0:25	**Play: Whole-story parade**	Walk around the room through the whole story with the moves: arms wide (God made it all good!), ear (Listen to God!), point to self (Me too), scrub (I can't wash it off!), door (Jesus is the door!), jump (Jesus is alive!), hug (Jesus welcomes me home!).
0:32	**Bible words**	"We love because he first loved us." (1 John 4:19). Break it into tiny pieces; children echo each one, then add the motions.
0:35	**Table time**	Kids' pages 2 and 3: Maze: run home to Jesus and Gates that open (cut and fold). Page 2: the maze home. Page 3: cut the two gate doors along the solid line and fold them open to find Jesus waiting. Then the last sticker on the Road Home chart, and the certificate.
0:47	**Snack: Welcome-home party**	Cupcakes or a party plate. Toast with juice: "Welcome home!" Then the talk questions (page 1).
0:53	**Say it, sticker, pray**	The Say it! with the moves once more (add a song you know if you like). Sticker on stop 7 of the Road Home chart. Pray: Invitation (no pressure): "I'm going to talk to Jesus. If you want to talk to Him like this too, you can whisper it with me. You don't have to." Pray slowly: "Dear Jesus, I'm sorry for the wrong things I do. Thank You for dying for me and coming alive again. Please make my heart clean. I want to follow You. Amen."
0:60	**Goodbye**	Pages 1–3 into bags. Do the Say it! with each parent at the door. Page 2's grown-ups box asks: "Who welcomes us home? Who can we tell about Jesus?"

Threes

Threes will copy whatever their friends do, so keep the invitation soft and quiet, and never count responses.

Teacher tip

Tell parents what was prayed, not who prayed it, and invite any parent whose child asks questions to talk with you or the pastor.

Fives

Fives may ask real questions. Welcome them, answer simply, and tell their parent the same day.

Handle with care

Preschoolers are eager to please and copy each other. Never ask for raised hands or for children to come forward, and never pressure. Plant the seed, tell parents, and trust God with the timing.

Answer keys and craft help

Week 1 · Count	Sun 1, trees 2, birds 3, fish 4, flowers 5.
Week 1 · Stick-a-garden	Any arrangement! Talk: “Who made the sun? The fish? You?”
Week 2 · Snakes	One in the left tree, one in the right tree, one on the middle bush, one in the grass at bottom right.
Week 2 · Story cards	Printed left to right: Out of the garden, The sneaky snake, Uh-oh!. Correct order: 1 The sneaky snake, 2 Uh-oh!, 3 Out of the garden.
Week 3 · Maze	One path only. Let children trace with a finger first.
Week 3 · Story cards	Printed left to right: All the people, God’s good rules, Adam and Eve leave. Correct order: 1 Adam and Eve leave, 2 All the people, 3 God’s good rules.
Week 4 · Soap	Circle the boot, plate, hands and dog. X on the heart: “Only God can make hearts clean.”
Week 4 · Story cards	Printed left to right: It won’t come off!, Locked out, Scrub, scrub…. Correct order: 1 Locked out, 2 Scrub, scrub…, 3 It won’t come off!.
Week 5 · Door craft	Cut the door on its three thick sides; fold along the dashed side. Cut the top panel off the page, glue it on the grey edges of the bottom panel so the door sits over the picture.
Week 6 · Tombs	The middle tomb is empty.
Week 6 · Stone craft	Push a paper fastener through the dot on the stone, then the dot beside the doorway, so the stone swings over the opening and rolls away.
Week 7 · Gates craft	Same as the door: cut the middle line and the top and bottom of the gates, fold on the dashed sides, glue the top panel over the picture.

Sources

1. Awana, “11 tips to maintain preschoolers’ attention, part 2” (2017). awana.org
2. Lifeway, “Eight ways preschoolers learn”. lifeway.com
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4. Awana, “8 tips for doing Scripture memory with preschoolers” (2018). awana.org
5. BibleCharts, “Methods for teaching preschoolers ages 3–5” (PDF). biblecharts.org
6. Ministry-to-Children, “6 quick classroom tips for engaging preschoolers”. ministry-to-children.com
7. Growing Hands-On Kids, “Scissor skill development checklist for ages 2–6”. growinghandsonkids.com

About the pictures

All pictures are frames from The Way Back Home book and its animated clips, by Johnny Wall. Colouring pages are simple hand-drawn outlines made for small hands.

Bible text

Scripture quotations are from the Christian Standard Bible®, © 2017 by Holman Bible Publishers. Used by permission. Short phrases are quoted from Genesis 1:31, Proverbs 30:5, Romans 3:23, Ephesians 2:8, John 3:16, Luke 24:6 and 1 John 4:19. “I am the door” is the book’s own wording of John 10:9 (CSB has “gate”).

Free to read and listen

The whole book, in many languages, is free at **thewaybackhome.net**. Families can scan the code on every week’s page 2.